# Savings Cooperative Launches RiverPassbook Boat Collection for Seven Mekong-Bank Villages

Tha Uthen Riverbank Savings Cooperative Ltd. · Press release PR-2026-09 · For immediate release, 1 October 2026

**THA UTHEN, NAKHON PHANOM, 1 October 2026** – Tha Uthen Riverbank Savings Cooperative Ltd. today announced RiverPassbook, a weekly boat collection service that will bring savings deposits, loan repayments and small withdrawals to members living in seven villages along the Mekong north and south of Tha Uthen town. The first trip departs on Monday 2 November 2026.

## 1. Why a boat?

Since March 2024 the cooperative has run a Saturday pickup-truck counter, but a 2025 member survey found that 38 per cent of members in the riverside villages had missed at least one monthly savings deposit because of travel problems. The pickup-truck counter will make its last run on Saturday 31 October 2026 and will be replaced by the boat.

The service uses the cooperative's own long-tail boat, the *Nam Oom 2*, fitted with a locked cash box and a handheld passbook terminal with a receipt printer. Every trip carries two staff: Boat Collection Officer Boonlert Phothisan and a second officer from the counter team, who takes turns according to the weekly roster.

## 2. Route and timetable

The boat leaves the cooperative's river landing behind the head office at 214 Chayangkun Road at 08:00 and stops for about 50 minutes at each village landing. The weekly pattern is:

- Monday (northern route): Ban Na Thon, Ban Don Toei and Ban Hat Kruat, returning by 12:30.
- Wednesday (southern route): Ban Phon Sawan, Ban Nong Khiat and Ban Kham Toei, returning by 13:00.
- Friday (island stop): Ban Don Sawan on Don Sawan island, the only village with no road link, from 09:00 to 11:00.

## 3. What members can do on board

- Savings deposits: from 20 baht up to 20,000 baht per member per visit. Larger deposits must be made at the head office counter.
- Loan repayments: any instalment on an existing cooperative loan, up to 20,000 baht per visit, counted separately from deposits.
- Withdrawals: up to 3,000 baht per member per visit from an ordinary savings account.

New loans, account opening and share purchases remain at the head office.

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**Flood period exception.** When the Tha Uthen District Office declares a local flood emergency, the withdrawal limit on the boat rises to 5,000 baht per member per visit until the declaration is lifted. The deposit and repayment limits do not change.

## 4. How to register

Members must register once before they can use RiverPassbook. Registration is free and takes about ten minutes:

1. Collect form RP-1 from the head office counter or from your village savings committee leader.
2. Fill in the form, choose your home landing and sign it before the committee leader or a counter officer.
3. Attach a copy of your national ID card and show your original passbook so that a QR sticker can be added to its back cover.
4. Hand in the form by Friday 23 October 2026 to be on the list for the first trip. Forms received later are added to the list on the following Monday.

On board, the officer scans the QR sticker, enters the amount, and prints a two-part receipt. The member checks the amount, signs one part, and keeps the other part. Members should keep their receipt slips for at least 60 days, until the transaction appears on their monthly statement.

## 5. Safety and cancelled trips

The boat does not sail when the river level at the Tha Uthen gauge is above 11.5 metres, during thunderstorms, or if only one officer is available. Cancellations are posted in each village's LINE group by 06:30 on the day of the trip. A cancelled Monday or Wednesday trip is replaced by a make-up trip on the next Saturday at the same times; a cancelled Friday island trip is replaced on the next Tuesday instead.

Cash on board is limited to 150,000 baht. When the cash box reaches this amount, the crew stops accepting deposits until they return to the landing, although withdrawals continue.

## 6. Fees and the Boat Saver bonus

RiverPassbook transactions are free of charge until 31 October 2027. After that, any fee will not exceed 5 baht per transaction. The ordinary savings rate stays at 1.75 per cent per year.

To encourage regular saving, members who make a boat deposit of at least 100 baht in each of the first 12 weeks of the service will receive a one-off Boat Saver bonus of 150 baht, credited to their savings account in February 2027. A missed week caused by a cancelled trip does not count against the member if they deposit on the make-up trip.

## 7. Comment from the cooperative

"Our river members have always saved; the road was the problem," said Kanyarat Sriwong, Manager of Tha Uthen Riverbank Savings Cooperative. "With RiverPassbook the counter comes to the landing."

Media contact: Siriporn Duangkaew, Member Relations Officer · Tel. 042 541 870 · press@thauthenriverbank-coop.example

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